

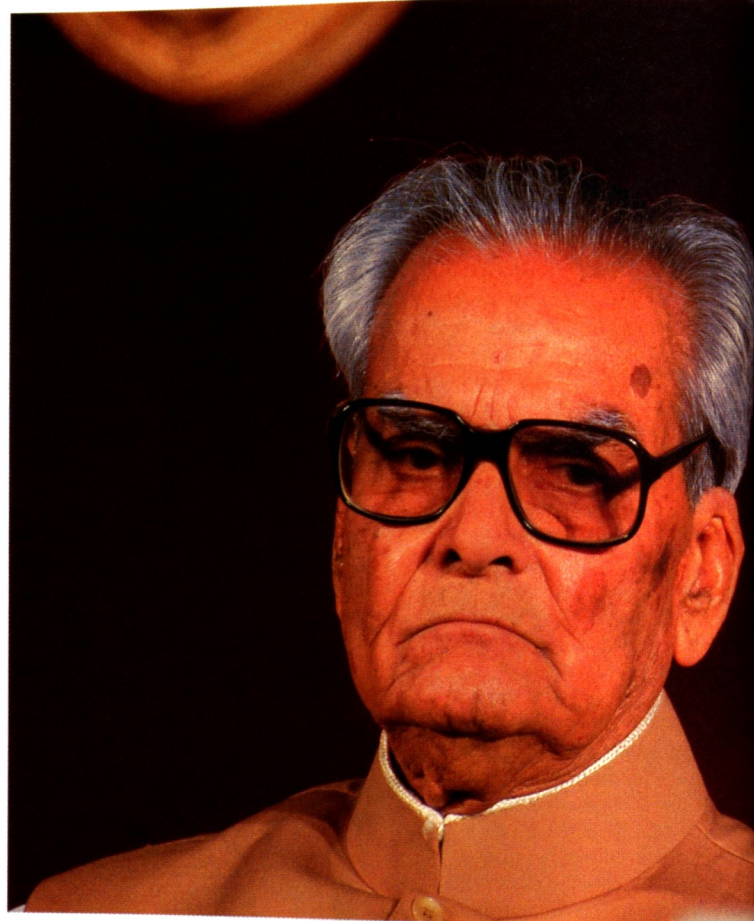
■ By Prabhu Chawla

Hukum, tell us why are you fighting this losing battle? The grand old Thakur, nursing a pouch of paan masala in his firm hands that hardly betray his 83 years, gives that what-do-you-know smirk and then laughs at the redundancy of the question. "Why are you asking me such a question?" asks Hukum (the deferential title for the head of a Thakur clan), as if you have missed the whole point about... er... "the mother" of all presidential battles.

For Bhairon Singh Shekhawat, the widely admired vice-president who wants to be the President, it is not about the imminence of defeat. It is all about his moral and political prerogative—about the spirit of democracy. In plainer terms, he puts it this way: there is a vacancy in the Rashtrapati Bhavan and the Indian Constitution calls for an election, sorry, not a nomination. He is only exercising his democratic right, and being Shekhawat, never the one to retreat from a good fight, he does it with so much panache. "Am I wrong? Am I committing any crime?" he asks as he makes himself more comfortable in a plush sofa during a freewheeling conversation with INDIA TODAY.

Conventional wisdom will say the answer is yes. Why is he ending such an illustrious career spanning 60 years in politics by fighting a hopeless battle? Why is he, one of India's finest practitioners of how to win friends and influence even enemies, squandering away the goodwill he had acquired from across the political spectrum in such a manner? What does he want to be known as in political history—an outstanding vice-president or the vice-president who was defeated by a controversial, lightweight presidential candidate? Isn't it more honourable for him to call it a day especially when the numbers are stacked against him, when the ruling establishment doesn't want this vice-president to be the President?

Unless there is a subterranean revolt in the UPA, Shekhawat won't be President. He knows that: he has the support of only 35 per cent of the electoral college of 10.98 lakh votes. The Thakur titan can prevent UPA candidate Pratibha Patil from becoming the



first woman President of India only if there is cross-voting by 50 MPs and 200 MLAs from the big states like Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh and West Bengal. Shekhawat, though, has no time for arithmetic. What drives him is not numbers but principles. As he sees it, the electorate should not be denied a choice, the cardinal principle of democracy. And he doesn't see himself as a political candidate. He resigned from BJP when he became a

vice-presidential candidate in 2002. According to election rules, no party can issue whip to its members to vote in favour of its candidate and the election is by secret ballot.

Shekhawat argues that the electoral college consisting of 776 MPs and 4,120 MLAs are electing a person for the highest non-political office of the republic. He believes he has the required credentials. He sees himself as the best choice in a bad situation, and his performance as Chairman of the Rajya Sabha is his undisputed qualification. Shekhawat has another original argument for his decision to contest. He wants to set a new democratic tradition: the political establishment should consecrate the principle of "making the vice-president the natural choice for the presidency". Vice-presidents were denied the chance only thrice in the past. Congress rejected the candidacy of V.V. Giri, but he

"The nation should not have a rubber stamp as President who signs every file without reading it."

B. S. SHEKHAWAT, VICE-PRESIDENT